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from the editor-in-chief

Russia has always fascinated India. In 1991, when the Soviet Union began to disintegrate, INDIA TODAY sent a correspondent to report on probably the most traumatic event in world history since the Second World War. In 2000, Russia seemed on the verge of collapse again at the end of the disastrous Boris Yeltsin era that had witnessed the rise of the oligarchs, the mafia and the Chechen movement. We decided to dispatch our foreign affairs expert Raj Chengappa to Moscow for an exclusive interview with the new President Vladimir Putin, who had the unenviable job of rescuing a country from chaos.

This week Putin oversaw a smooth transfer of power to President Dmitri Medvedev, who took over a very different country, an ambitious, forward-looking Russia. In eight years under Putin, Russia's GDP growth has been a healthy 7 per cent. It is one of the world's largest oil exporters and has a nuclear arsenal second only to the US. Russia has a 55 million-strong middle class and 101 billionaires. This has been a remarkable transformation and we decided it was the right time to revisit a Russia redeemed from virtual anarchy by Putin, a very modern Czar.

Putin has turned his country around, bringing back Central control, quelling the separatists and energising the economy. He has created a whole new genre of leadership, men like Medvedev, who are far removed from the dour and secretive communist commissars of the past. It is not as if there are no problems. There is corruption, over-dependence on oil exports and an indigenous industrial sector that is a decade behind the world. But for the first time since the break-up of the Soviet Union, Mother Russia has stability and a sense of purpose.



Our Oct 2000 cover

Our cover story on the new Russia was written by Managing Editor Chengappa who travelled to the country again to study the Putin effect. He found a nation that had left its past behind and was being led by a new generation of young politicians and confident and aspirational citizens. "The stereotype of the lazy, vodka-drinking Russian is far removed from today's reality," says Chengappa.

Russians though seemed to have one major question for him—"Where are the Indians?" An increasingly consumerist country is being wooed by businesses from China and Europe but India, Russia's most staunch ally during the Cold War, seems stuck in a time warp, and mutual trade is strictly old economy, still restricted to tea, textiles, minerals and arms. Russia is a country where India's ambitious and enterprising community could fit right into.

Beyond business, Russia's increasing assertiveness in the international arena means that this is the right time for India to rekindle its old Cold War comradeship with a lot more intensity. We need more friendship. As the Russians say, "Za Druzhu".

Aroon Purie

(Aroon Purie)